Recommendation Report

Central west Orana renewable energy zone

prepared for the big friendly philanthropy team :)

context

the central-west orana REZ is nsw's first big attempt at a large-scale renewable zone — cleaner power, jobs, investment flowing into towns that don't usually get any. but it's turned into a trust problem. the podcast's whole point is that communities feel decisions are happening about them, not with them [1], and that's less a technology issue than a people one [2]. farmers, traditional owners, local businesses, councils and energy companies all imagine a different future for the same land [1]. the challenge isn't to convince anyone renewables are good, it's making the process feel fair and letting people see that they can actually gain something, not just hosting someone else's infrastructure [1].

recommendation 1 - run permanent citizen juries

the ABC's citizen jury worked because it put residents and officials in the same room, instead of explaining decisions after they'd already been made [1]. big friendly's communicators can unpack the data and trade-offs, translating jargon into visuals and plain language that people can engage with which creates a safe, structured space for locals to genuinely deliberate, lowering tension and building real consensus.

recommendation 2 - move to community co-ownership

instead of treating community benefit as a payout, residents near the infrastructure should get an actual stake in it, like co-ownership of the assets and not just a cheque from a fund [4]. that shifts the relationship from "we're compensating you" to "this is partly yours" and fixes the split where landholders who host infrastructure get paid and neighbours who just live next to it get nothing [3]. our team can run workshops explaining the financials, so residents genuinely understand how they share in long-term profits, flipping the narrative from exploitation to shared regional wealth.

recommendation 3 - keep an honest scorecard

someone independent needs to keep score on how this is actually going, not EnergyCo, which has an obvious incentive to report success, and not a single inquiry that happens once [2]. a monitor could track both the practical and the human side over time, and publish it openly [2]. right now those live in separate reports that never talk to each other, which is how you get two totally different accounts of the same project. all over the place. big friendly's communicators could turn that tracking into something the public actually reads.

reference list(its barely a sentence from each(sorry)):

[1] ABC's CITIZEN JURY — *Would you live inside a modern power station? These people will, and want to be heard*

[2] *Impact of Renewable Energy Zones (REZ) on rural and regional communities and industries in New South Wales* (First Report: Central-West Orana REZ, August 2025). (https://www.parliament.nsw.gov.au/fileapi/parlfiles/getartifact?serverRelativeUrl=/tp/files/191603/Report%20No.%2062%20-%20Impact%20of%20Renewable%20Energy%20Zones%20(REZ)%20-%20First%20Report%20-%2021%20August%202025.pdf, pages vii, viii, 45)

[3] *Energy Transition Team: Responding to transmission and renewable energy infrastructure complaints* (published in *EWON Insights*, April–June 2025 edition). (https://www.ewon.com.au/page/publications-and-submissions/reports/EWON-Insights/ewon-insights-apr---jun-2025/energy-transition-team-responding-to-transmission-and-renewable-energy-infrastructure-complaints, “Dissatisfied with transmission line placement”)

[4] *Benefit-Sharing Guideline: Guidance for large-scale renewable energy projects* (NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure, November 2024). (https://www.planning.nsw.gov.au/sites/default/files/2024-11/benefit-sharing-guideline.pdf, page 12)

~~AI declaration-

i used AI to help me frame the reference list since i only had links for the material. i’ve never really written anything that requires working with citations before, so this was new :) i hope i did it justice !

(https://share.gemini.google/J3SupWDES8il)